

חֶמֶר מְדִינָה

Chamar Medina — Kiddush & Havdalah on Coffee

When there is no wine — or no desire for it — may the national drink stand in? Coffee as chamar medina for kiddush, havdalah, and the melave malka table.

THE QUESTIONS ON THE TABLE השאלות

1 Is there a distinction between hot black coffee and cold black coffee for chamar medina?

Machloket. The Grishza holds one should not serve cold coffee for kiddush/havdalah even though it is common to drink, because cold coffee is not...

2 Does coffee with milk or without milk affect its status as chamar medina for kiddush/havdalah?

Machloket. Some hold that coffee with milk is not chamar medina since it is no longer plain coffee.

3 Does coffee with sugar vs. without sugar affect its chamar medina status for kiddush/havdalah?

Coffee even without sugar may qualify as chamar medina according to many poskim.

4 Is there a distinction between regular brewed coffee and instant coffee (נמס) regarding chamar medina?

The Grishza holds there is no distinction — instant coffee (נמס) has the same status as brewed coffee for chamar medina purposes.

5 May coffee, tea, or other soft drinks/juices be used for kiddush or havdalah?

No. Tea, coffee, and other juices and soft drinks may not be used for kiddush or havdalah, as they do not qualify as chamar medina.

6 May one recite kiddush or havdalah over coffee when no wine is available?

Yes — under extenuating circumstances, one may recite kiddush or havdalah over coffee.

7 May one drink coffee on Shabbos morning before davening, and before making kiddush?

Coffee may be drunk before Shabbos morning davening (see separate davening entry). After davening, one may not eat or drink before kiddush.

8 Can coffee (without food) fulfill the obligation of melave malka (the fourth Shabbos meal eaten after havdalah)?

Coffee alone may suffice for melave malka for one who cannot eat solid food.

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Kitzur Shulchan Aruch - Shulchan HaMelech (Laniado) ↗

"I have set Hashem before me always." 1Psalms 16:8. This is a fundamental rule of the Torah and of the attributes of the righteous who walk before God. For we cannot compare a person's lifestyle, his activities and affairs when he is alone, to his lifestyle, and activities and affairs when he is before a great king.

שויתי ה' לנגדי תמיד, הוא כלל גדול בתורה ובמעלות הצדיקים אשר הולכים לפני האלהים. כי אין ישיבת האדם תנועתו ועסקיו והוא לבדו בביתו, כמו ישיבתו ותנועתו ועסקיו כאשר הוא לפני מלך גדול.

WORTH ARGUING ABOUT צריך עיון

- What makes a drink chamar medina — that people drink it socially, that it commands respect, or that it could replace wine at a formal table? Coffee tests every definition.
- Daytime kiddush is more lenient than night, and havdalah more lenient still for some poskim — notice which cup each source is actually talking about.
- Ask the practical question: if coffee qualifies, does it need to be black? A full cup? Drunk by the one making havdalah?



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